
ACQLERATE

Defense Acquisitions Academy

GovCon Onboarding Playbook

How to onboard new hires into
DoD acquisition in 30 days

A practical guide from Acqlerate — Defense Acquisitions Academy

Why This Matters

Most GovCon new hires spend 6–12 months learning defense acquisition through osmosis. They sit in meetings they don't fully understand, read contracts they can't parse, and slowly piece together how the DoD buys things. It's slow, inconsistent, and expensive.

The cost isn't just time. Uninformed team members make avoidable mistakes—wrong color of money on a funding document, confusion between an IDIQ vehicle and a task order, unauthorized commitments because they didn't know who holds contractual authority. These errors erode customer trust and create real compliance risk.

A structured 30-day onboarding plan changes the equation:

- Fewer mistakes in the first 90 days
- Better proposal quality from day one
- Faster contribution to program execution
- A repeatable process—not a one-time lucky hire

This playbook is for team leads, program directors, and hiring managers who want a repeatable system for bringing new PMs, BD staff, capture managers, and analysts up to speed on DoD acquisition—quickly and consistently.

It pairs a structured week-by-week framework with Acqlerate's self-paced learning modules to deliver practical fluency—not just compliance awareness—in 30 days.

The 30-Day Framework

The onboarding plan is organized into three phases. Each phase builds on the last, moving from foundational knowledge to hands-on application to independent operation.

1

Foundation

"Understand the landscape"

Week 1–2 • Days 1–14

2

Application

"Apply it to your program"

Week 3 • Days 15–21

3

Integration

"Operate independently"

Week 4 • Days 22–30

Phase	Timeline	Goal	Key Activities
Foundation	Days 1–14	Understand the landscape	Core modules, contract review, program briefing
Application	Days 15–21	Apply to your program	Shadow activities, role-specific learning, first deliverable
Integration	Days 22–30	Operate independently	Independent tasks, risk identification, assessment quiz

Week 1–2: Foundations

Days 1–14 • “Understand the landscape”

The first two weeks are about building a shared vocabulary and baseline understanding. The new hire should focus on four core topics:

- What is DoD acquisition? The acquisition lifecycle, key players (PM, CO, COR, DCMA), and common contract types (FFP, CPFF, T&M, IDIQ).
- How does the government buy? Standalone contracts vs. task orders, IDIQ vehicles, fair opportunity process, and the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR).
- What is color of money? Appropriations categories (RDT&E, O&M, Procurement), fiscal year rules, and why Anti-Deficiency Act (ADA) violations matter.
- The three career tracks: USG Program Manager, Contractor PM, and Contracting Officer—different roles, different authorities, different incentives.

Recommended Acqlerate Modules

Foundations (free) + Contracting Fundamentals. Estimated 4–5 hours total.

Day 1 Checklist

- ☐ Set up Acqlerate account (free) at acqlerate.com
- ☐ Complete Foundations intro lesson
- ☐ Read the Acquisition Starter Kit
- ☐ Meet with PM / program lead for program context briefing
- ☐ Review the contract / task order they'll be working under

Week 3: Application

Days 15–21 • “Apply it to your program”

Week 3 shifts from learning to doing. The new hire applies their foundational knowledge to real program activities:

- Shadow one contract review, program review, or proposal activity to see acquisition concepts in context.
- Complete the Acqlerate module most relevant to their role (BD → Capture module; PM → Finance or Data module).
- Identify one concept they’re still unclear on—use the AI study assistant in Acqlerate to resolve it.
- Review their first CDRL (Contract Data Requirements List) or deliverable requirement.

Role-Specific Guidance

Contractor PM	BD / Capture	Proposal Analyst
Focus on the Contracts module. Learn EVM (Earned Value Management) basics. Understand your task order SOW inside and out.	Complete the Capture Management module. Understand the difference between Section L (Instructions) and Section M (Evaluation Criteria).	Work through the pricing volume checklist. Study the past performance template. Learn source selection basics.

Week 4: Integration

Days 22–30 • “Operate independently”

By the end of Week 4, the new hire should be able to operate with minimal hand-holding. Here’s what “ready” looks like:

- Describe the acquisition lifecycle in plain English—from requirements to award to execution.
- Explain what type of contract their program uses and why it matters for risk and billing.
- Know who the CO, COR, and DCMA representative are on their program—and what each one controls.
- Understand what color of money funds their program and the fiscal year constraints.
- Identify 2–3 risks on their program and describe how they’re being mitigated.

Assessment

Give the new hire the 10-question Acqlerate assessment quiz covering acquisition lifecycle, contract types, color of money, and roles & authorities. If they pass, they’re ready to contribute independently. If not, target the specific gaps with module reviews.

30-Day Milestone Summary

Day	Milestone	Verified By
Day 1	Acqlerate account created, first lesson complete	Progress dashboard
Day 7	Foundations module complete, Starter Kit read	Module completion badge
Day 14	Contracting Fundamentals complete, contract reviewed	Team lead check-in
Day 21	Role-specific module done, first deliverable reviewed	Module completion + debrief
Day 30	Assessment quiz passed, operating independently	Quiz score + PM sign-off

Common Mistakes to Avoid

These five mistakes come up again and again with new GovCon hires. Avoiding them in the first 30 days saves months of course correction.

1. Skipping the contract review

The SOW tells you what's actually authorized. Read it before week 1 ends. Everything you do on a government contract traces back to this document—scope, deliverables, period of performance, and funding. If you haven't read it, you're guessing.

2. Confusing the IDIQ with the task order

The vehicle gets you in the door. The task order is your actual contract. IDIQ vehicles set ceiling values and general terms, but the task order defines your specific scope, funding, and deliverables. Know which one governs your work.

3. Ignoring color of money

Using O&M funds for something that should be RDT&E is an Anti-Deficiency Act violation. Know the difference. Appropriations categories aren't bureaucratic trivia—they're legal constraints with real consequences.

4. Treating the COR like a boss

The COR monitors performance. Only the CO can change your contract. Knowing this prevents unauthorized commitments. If the COR asks you to do something outside your SOW, the correct response is "Let me check with the CO."

5. Assuming DAU training = operational fluency

Compliance training and practical fluency are different things. Build both. DAU courses cover policy and regulation. Acqlerate builds the practical judgment to apply that knowledge in real contract and program situations.

Recommended Acqlerate Learning Path

Every role starts with Foundations (Module 01)—it's free and gives everyone a common baseline. From there, the path diverges based on what each role needs most.

Role	Modules (in order)	Est. Completion
Contractor PM	Foundations → Contracts → Finance → Data → Ops	8–10 hours
BD / Capture	Foundations → Capture → Contracts	5–6 hours
Proposal Analyst	Foundations → Capture → Contracts	5–6 hours
Contracting Officer	Foundations → Contracts → Finance	6–7 hours
Financial Analyst	Foundations → Finance → Data	5–6 hours

How to Use This Table

Start every new hire on Foundations—it's free and takes about 2 hours. Then assign the role-specific path. Most team members can complete their full track within the 30-day window alongside their regular onboarding activities. Use Acqlerate's progress dashboard to track completion and quiz scores.

Module Descriptions

- Foundations (Free): DoD acquisition lifecycle, key players, contract types, and career paths. The shared language every team member needs.
- Contracts: IDIQ vehicles, task orders, FAR essentials, SOW interpretation, contract modifications, and unauthorized commitments.
- Finance: Color of money, appropriations law, EVM basics, funding documents, and ADA compliance.
- Capture: Capture management process, competitive analysis, Section L/M, teaming agreements, and win strategy development.
- Data: Program data analysis, reporting requirements, CDRLs, and performance metrics.
- Ops: Day-to-day program execution, risk management, subcontractor oversight, and government reporting.

Ready to Build a Sharper Team?

Acqlerate is free to start. Module 01—DoD Acquisitions Foundations—is completely free for every team member. No credit card. No approval chain. Just create an account and start learning.

Upgrading unlocks all six modules, the AI study assistant, and quizzes with progress tracking—everything your team needs to go from new hire to operationally fluent in 30 days.

- ✓ Start any team member free today at acqlerate.com
- ✓ No classroom scheduling. No per-seat contract negotiations.
- ✓ Self-paced learning they'll actually complete.

The defense acquisition workforce is growing, but the knowledge pipeline hasn't kept up. Your team doesn't need another multi-day classroom course. They need a structured, self-paced path from "I just got hired" to "I understand how this program works."

That's what Acqlerate builds.

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